StoryCast: Research and Design

1. Introduction

For this project, I decided to create **StoryCast**, a small editorial website where people can discover and read stories, with the option to listen to them as well. The main idea is to make reading feel more enjoyable while also making the website easy to use for people with different needs and preferences.

I wanted the website to feel calm, welcoming, and focused on the stories themselves. Instead of using too many colours or complicated layouts, I chose a simple design with warm colours, clear text, and enough space between sections.

Accessibility was also an important part of the project. A website should not only look good but should also be usable by people who navigate with a keyboard, use screen readers, or have difficulty reading certain text styles.

2. Project Goals

The main goal was to design and build a responsive editorial website that works well on both computers and smaller screens.

The website needed to:

- Help visitors discover featured stories.
- Provide a dedicated page where readers can focus on one story.
- Introduce the purpose of StoryCast and explain its approach to accessibility.
- Use a consistent design across all three pages.
- Make the content easy to read and navigate.
- Include basic accessibility features, such as clear headings, keyboard-friendly links, and readable colour combinations.

I also wanted to practise using HTML and Sass to organise the project properly instead of placing all the styling in one large file.

3. Target Audience

StoryCast is intended for people who enjoy reading stories online and want a simple way to discover new content. This could include students, casual readers, and people who prefer listening to stories rather than reading everything on a screen.

Since visitors may use different devices and have different accessibility needs, the website should be easy to navigate and should not depend entirely on images or visual design to communicate information.

4. Website Structure

I divided the website into three main pages. Each page has a different purpose, but they all follow the same visual style.

Home Page: `index.html`

The home page introduces StoryCast and gives visitors a place to start. It includes the main heading, a featured story, information about the project, and a short introduction to its accessibility features.

The goal is to help visitors understand what the website offers without making them search through too much information.

Story Page: `story/index.html`

This page focuses on one story, titled *The Keepers of the Tide*. It includes the story's title, introductory information, and the main reading area.

I also included an audio player area and a transcript section. The transcript is intended to help visitors access the story's content in text form. The audio feature still depends on adding a working audio file.

About and Accessibility Page: `about.html`

This page explains the purpose behind StoryCast and the design choices made for accessibility. It gives visitors more information about the project and highlights the importance of making digital content easier for different people to use.

Sitemap

The website follows a simple structure:

StoryCast
│
├── Home
│ ├── Featured Story
│ ├── About StoryCast
│ └── Accessibility Preview
│
├── Story
│ ├── Story Introduction
│ ├── Story Content
│ ├── Audio Player
│ └── Transcript
│
└── About & Accessibility

```
├── Project Mission
├── Design Approach
└── Accessibility Features
```

This structure keeps the website straightforward and makes it easier for visitors to move between the pages.

5. Wireframes and Layout Planning

Before settling on the final layout, I considered how the main sections should be arranged and how visitors would move through the website.

The home page places the introduction and featured story near the top so visitors can quickly understand the purpose of the site. Supporting information appears further down the page.

The story page uses a more focused layout to reduce distractions and make reading more comfortable. The audio and transcript sections are placed alongside the story content in the page flow.

The About and Accessibility page uses clear sections to separate the project's mission from the accessibility information.

The following sketches show the basic layout ideas behind the three pages.

Home Page Wireframe

```
+--------------------------------------+
| StoryCast          Home | About      |
+--------------------------------------+
|                                      |
|      Stories worth staying for       |
|      Short introduction              |
|      [ Explore stories ]             |
|                                      |
+--------------------------------------+
| Featured Story                       |
| Image / Illustration                 |
| Title and short description          |
| [ Read story ]                       |
+--------------------------------------+
| About StoryCast                      |
| Short description                    |
+--------------------------------------+
| Accessibility Preview                |
+--------------------------------------+
| Footer                               |
+--------------------------------------+
```

Story Page Wireframe

```
+-------------------------------------+
| StoryCast          Home | About     |
+-------------------------------------+
| Story category                      |
| The Keepers of the Tide             |
| Short introduction                  |
+-------------------------------------+
| Story Illustration                  |
+-------------------------------------+
|                                     |
| Main Story Text                     |
|                                     |
+-------------------------------------+
| Audio Player                        |
| Transcript (expandable)             |
+-------------------------------------+
| Footer                              |
+-------------------------------------+
```

About and Accessibility Wireframe

```
+-------------------------------------+
| StoryCast          Home | About     |
+-------------------------------------+
| About StoryCast                     |
| Introduction                        |
+-------------------------------------+
| Our Mission                         |
| Project purpose                     |
+-------------------------------------+
| Accessibility                       |
| Readability, navigation and content |
+-------------------------------------+
| Footer                              |
+-------------------------------------+
```

These are low-fidelity wireframes, meaning they focus on the placement of content rather than the final colours, fonts, or decorative details.

6. Visual Design

I chose a colour palette that gives StoryCast a warm and slightly editorial appearance. The darker colours provide contrast, while the cream background makes the pages feel softer and less harsh than a plain white layout.

The main colours are:

Colour	Hex Code	How it is used
Navy	`#18243A`	Main headings and dark sections
Cream	`#F7F1E7`	Page backgrounds
Terracotta	`#B84F32`	Accent colours and important links
Charcoal	`#20242B`	Main body text
Slate	`#5D6470`	Secondary text
Warm Border	`#D9D0C3`	Borders and section dividers

I wanted the colours to work together without making the website look too busy. The navy gives the design structure, while the cream and terracotta add warmth.

For typography, I chose **DM Serif Display** for large headings and **DM Sans** for body text and interface elements. The serif font gives the headings more personality, while the sans-serif font keeps paragraphs and navigation clear and easy to read.

I also used spacing and simple layouts to separate sections and make the content easier to follow.

7. Illustrations and Visual Elements

The website uses a coastal-inspired visual direction that fits the featured story, *The Keepers of the Tide*. The illustration helps establish the mood of the story and gives the website a recognisable visual identity.

I kept the surrounding layout relatively simple so the illustration would support the content rather than compete with it.

Where images are used to communicate important information, suitable alternative text should be provided. Decorative images should not create unnecessary noise for people using screen readers.

8. Accessibility Considerations

Accessibility was considered throughout the design and development process. I wanted the website to be usable by more people, rather than focusing only on how it looks.

Some of the main considerations were:

- **Readable text:** Using clear fonts, suitable text sizes, and enough spacing between paragraphs.
- **Colour contrast:** Choosing text and background colours that are easier to distinguish.

- **Keyboard navigation:** Making sure visitors can move through links and controls without needing a mouse.
- **Clear page structure:** Using headings and semantic HTML elements to organise the content.
- **Descriptive links:** Using link text that gives visitors an idea of where the link will take them.
- **Alternative text:** Providing meaningful descriptions for informative images.
- **Text transcripts:** Including a transcript section so visitors have a text-based way to access audio content.
- **Responsive design:** Making the website usable on mobile phones, tablets, and desktop screens.

These choices help make the website more inclusive. However, including accessibility features in the design does not automatically mean the website is fully accessible. Testing with a keyboard, checking colour contrast, and using accessibility tools are still important.

9. Technical Implementation

I built StoryCast using HTML and Sass.

HTML provides the structure and content for each page. Sass is used to organise the styling into smaller files, which makes it easier to maintain and update the design.

The Sass project is divided into partials for different purposes, including colours, typography, spacing, layout, components, resets, and accessibility-related styles. These files are brought together through the main Sass file and compiled into `css/main.css`, which the HTML pages use.

The website is organised into three HTML pages, with the story page inside its own folder. Images and other media are stored in separate asset folders.

This structure makes the project easier to understand and helps keep the code organised as the website develops.

10. Testing and Limitations

During development, I checked that the pages loaded correctly and that the styles were being applied. I also reviewed the layout and navigation to make sure the pages followed a consistent design.

There are still areas that need to be checked before the project can be considered complete.

These include:

- Testing the layout at different screen sizes.
- Checking navigation using only a keyboard.
- Reviewing colour contrast and text readability.
- Checking for HTML and CSS errors.

- Testing links between all three pages.
- Confirming that the audio player works once an audio file is added.
- Making sure the transcript accurately matches the audio, if audio is included.
- Testing the published website after deployment.

The audio player is a limitation if the project is submitted without an actual audio file. In that case, the audio feature should be described as a planned feature or prototype rather than a fully working one.

The wireframes in this document are basic layout sketches. If the assignment requires visual mockups made in Figma, and included with the final submission.

11. Conclusion

Working on StoryCast gave me an opportunity to practise building a small multi-page website while thinking about design, accessibility, and code organisation.

One of the main things I focused on was keeping the website simple and consistent. Each page has a clear purpose, and the same colours, fonts, and layout principles are used throughout the project.

The project also helped me understand that accessibility should be considered from the beginning rather than added at the very end. Clear navigation, readable text, and alternative ways to access content can make a website more useful to a wider range of people.

Overall, StoryCast is a starting point for an editorial website that combines storytelling with a more thoughtful approach to design and accessibility. There is still room to improve and test the site, but the current structure provides a foundation for future development.